threat to US hegemony, aspiring to have more power and participation in the international order, with demands to the traditional powers to adjust rules and standards accordingly. Others have celebrated the rise of the BRICS as the democratisation of the world order, without which it will be impossible to find solutions to the global financial crisis which began in the US.

Because of the BRICS' apparent importance, funding agencies began to allocate resources to projects and academic papers on the topic, and the BRICS states also officially supported alliances of generally pro-government, pro-business academics and think tanks. In early 2015, the Russian government established a 'Civic BRICS' to involve 500 approved representatives from the five countries plus guest countries. The strategy was in part, according to the civilbrics.ru website, 'to make decisions made at the Summit more legitimate,' which in turn led the main Brazilian civil society network (Rebrip) to formally dissociate from the process, given Putin's record of repressing Russian NGOs hostile to the Moscow regime.

Even though three of the five BRICS were suffering severe economic problems by 2015, with the end of China's boom adding to world economic dislocation, much of the analysis coming from mainstream academics and NGOs has been upbeat in tone. The texts gathered below aim to fill a gap in studies, events and documents dealing with BRICS: critical analysis of these economies and societies within the framework of a global capitalism that is increasingly predatory, exclusionary and unequal, in many cases quite explicitly so within the BRICS themselves. We take up the challenge of bringing together a set of chapters from different approaches, albeit all 'anti-capitalist', reflecting upon the uncertain rise of a 'Global South (and East)', which is sometimes cooperative with and sometimes antagonistic to the traditional powers (US, Europe and Japan, plus the main multilateral institutions).

Most importantly, the BRICS' rise occurs in the context of the expansion and deepening of capitalism in the 21st century, and also in the midst of world capitalism's worst crisis since the 1930s. The point of critical anti-capitalist analysis of this sort is to thereby strengthen understandings of where BRICS fit in the world economy and global governance, how their own companies' capital accumulation strategies are developing, how national political dynamics comply, and how networks of resistance have begun to respond. The goal is simple: contribute to building transnational solidarity towards a 'BRICS from below' that genuinely defends the interests of people, environment and sovereignty in both BRICS and their hinterlands, against the depredations of capitalism.